

Public Policy 301: Evidence and Policy
Autumn 2025 – Tuesday/Thursday 1-2:20pm (PAR 320)
Quiz Section Friday 1:30-2:20/2:30-3:20pm (PAR 160)

Instructor: Crystal Hall (halcc@uw.edu)
Parrington Hall 240B | 206.221.5237
Office Hours schedule: <https://calendly.com/crystalhall>
(please reach out if these times do not work for you)

TA: Mark Nepf (mnepf@uw.edu)
Office Hours schedule:
Tue 10:30am-12:30pm, Thu 11am-1pm
PAR 155 or <https://washington.zoom.us/j/2911282211>

Course Overview

Sound public policy and governance decisions rely on having evidence to support conclusions, as well as understanding the extent of certainty regarding the available evidence. This course examines the way that evidence is interpreted and applied in policymaking. Students will explore the practical and political realities of using evidence in these settings, through an examination of case studies and other resources. By the end of the class, students will be able to analyze and discuss real-world policy challenges and communicate evidence informed arguments to a diverse range of audiences.

By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Explain how evidence shapes policymaking, including examples of its historic use in policy debates.
- Identify the political and cultural factors that impact when and how evidence is used.
- Evaluate the strengths and limitations of different types of evidence (such as administrative, qualitative, and experimental sources of evidence).
- Assess the ethical and equity implications of evidence use in public policy.
- Apply evidence to build arguments for or against specific policy proposals.
- Communicate clearly and persuasively about evidence to diverse audiences

Course Structure

This course is designed to be interactive and applied. Each week will combine a short lecture to introduce key concepts, small-group discussions to explore ideas in depth, and class-wide activities that connect evidence to real-world policy examples. To support active engagement, students will:

- Participate in small group work where you will debate case studies, analyze evidence, and practice applying course concepts.
- Engage in short lectures and discussions that provide background, highlight key debates, and connect readings to broader policy issues.
- Take occasional in-class pop quizzes (unannounced) that check your understanding of the readings and lecture material. These are meant to keep everyone on track, not to penalize, and together they make up a small portion of your grade.
- Complete applied exercises that build toward a final project.

This mix of approaches is meant to help you not just learn about evidence in policy, but also practice analyzing, debating, and communicating about it.

Text and Readings

Required: Haskins, R., & Margolis, G. (2014). *Show me the evidence: Obama's fight for rigor and results in social policy*. Brookings Institution Press.

Optional: Nutley, S., Walter, I. and Davies, H. (2007) *Using evidence: How research can inform public services*, Bristol: The Policy Press. *(I will provide some excerpts from this book)*

Additional readings available on course website: <https://canvas.uw.edu/courses/1921956>

Note: Canvas is the primary information source for this course. All course materials/announcements will be posted to that space. Slides and supplemental materials will also be available there after class. The syllabus is subject to change, but the information on Canvas will be current. Please notify me immediately if you notice any errors or have questions about material on Canvas.

Course Schedule and Topics

	Topic	Dates		Reading Assignment
Week 1	Introductions and discuss why we are here		Oct 1	No readings!
Week 2	NO CLASS	Oct 6	Oct 8	
Week 3/4	What is evidence and what does it mean to “use” evidence in policymaking?	Oct 13	Oct 15	UE: Ch. 1 & 2
		Oct 20	Oct 22	SME: Ch. 1
Weeks 5/6	Types of evidence	Oct 27	Oct 29	SME Ch. 2
		Nov 3	Nov 5 NO CLASS	SME Ch. 3
Week 7	Interpreting and contesting policy claims	Nov 10	Nov 12	SME Ch. 4 & 5
Week 8	Ethical and equity implications of evidence use	Nov 17	Nov 19	SME Ch. 6
Week 9	Building evidence-informed policy arguments	Nov 24	Nov 26 NO CLASS	SME Ch. 7
Week 10	Effective communication about evidence	Dec 1	Dec 3	Readings TBD
Week 11	Final presentations: Evidence in action!	Dec 8	Dec 10	No readings!

UE: *Using Evidence*

SME: *Show Me the Evidence*

*Note: reading assignments are due at the start of the week in which they are assigned.

Grading and Assignments

Assignment	Date	Percent	Points
Class participation	Ongoing	35%	350
Equity/ethics essay	Nov. 6 th	20%	200
In-class essay discussion	Nov. 10 th	10%	100
Group presentation	Dec. 8 nd and 10 th	20%	200
Feedback to other groups	Dec. 8 nd and 10 th	5%	50
Group memo	Dec. 11 th	10%	100
TOTAL		100%	1000

Class participation: This class will be heavily participation based. Participation will be evaluated based on the following:

- Preparation: Coming to class having completed the readings and ready to engage with them.
- Engagement: Contributing thoughtfully to small-group and full-class discussions, listening respectfully to others, and helping create a constructive learning environment.
- Collaboration: Working productively with peers during in-class activities, including group debates, case analyses, and policy exercises.
- Accountability: Being present, attentive, and contributing consistently over the course of the quarter.

Participation does not mean speaking the most, it means being a reliable, engaged member of the class community.

Occasional in-class pop quizzes (worth 10 points each) will also serve as a check on preparation, and these will count toward your participation grade. You will **not** be able to make up any missed pop quizzes, so be sure to attend class (and arrive on time). I will drop the lowest score of all of the quizzes at the end of the quarter.

Quiz section: The quiz section will be a space to develop your group projects. These sessions will be a mix of work time, informal presentations, and opportunities to give and receive feedback to your peers. Occasional graded exercises in quiz section will contribute to your class participation grade. If you miss quiz section without contacting the TA in advance, you forfeit the opportunity to earn those points.

Ethics/equity essay: This assignment will require you to provide a critical analysis of the way that evidence has been used in a particular policy area. You will submit an individual essay and provide feedback to some classmates in an in-class session. Students missing class on this day (**Nov. 10th**) will be required to make up this portion of class in a 1-1 meeting with me.

Group presentation and memo: Your final project is an opportunity to demonstrate what you have learned about how evidence is used in policymaking. You will select a specific policy issue and develop an evidence-informed argument either for or against a proposed policy or program. The project combines written and oral communication skills and allows you to practice presenting evidence clearly to a diverse audience.

Project Requirements:

- **Policy Focus:** Select a policy issue that interests you. This may be drawn from national, state, or local policy.
- **Evidence Base:** Use at least two different types of evidence (e.g., administrative data, qualitative research, experiments) to support your argument.
- **Equity and Ethics:** Address the ethical and equity implications of the evidence you use.
- **Policy Brief:** Create a concise policy brief (due **Dec. 11th**) that summarizes your argument and provides key evidence in an accessible format.
- **Presentation:** Deliver a presentation during the last week of class, followed by Q&A with your peers.

Peer Feedback (Required): An important part of this project is learning to give and receive constructive feedback. In class during the final week of class, you will also provide feedback to your classmates on their analysis and presentations.

Late Assignment Policy

Any assignment received after the due date will be docked 10 points per day (24-hour period). If you would like to request an assignment extension, please do so at least 12 hours *before* the assignment deadline, otherwise the late penalty will apply.

General Course Expectations

- **Attendance:** Please carefully review the class participation guidelines. Pop-quizzes can not be made up (but the lowest score will be dropped). To request an excused absence, please reach out 48 hours in advance of the session you will miss. I will consider exceptions for last-minute emergencies on a case by case basis.
- If you miss class, please review the posted material on Canvas, connect with a classmate, and then reach out to me with any questions about what we covered.
- When communicating with me and your classmates, please consider the format, tone, and general professionalism of both email and verbal communication. Please strive to give, request, and receive feedback in a way that encourages listening and personal growth.
- Avoid leaving the classroom during our time together, please feel free to sit or stand, depending on your preferences, and let me know if there are ways I can make your experience in the classroom more comfortable.
- In order to have an engaging dialogue and out of respect to your fellow classmates, there will be no portable electronics use during class, unless specifically requested by the instructor or TA. This includes: laptops, electronic notebooks, ipads, cell phones, and other electronics. All course slides and handouts will be uploaded to Canvas for your reference and handouts will be provided in class.

Conversation Guidelines

I expect that all students will engage in a professional manner, keeping in mind the wide array of backgrounds and perspectives represented in our classroom. Specifically, all students should keep in mind the Evans School Community Commitments:

At the Evans School, we value and honor the experiences and perspectives that each person brings to our community. As a professional school, we have a responsibility to engage each other—inside and outside of the classroom—in a manner consistent with our values of Equity, Service and Courage. As a community we commit to:

- *Acknowledge, reflect on, and examine individual and systemic power, injustice, privilege, and biases*
- *Work and collaborate to expand our knowledge using empirical evidence, lived experience, storytelling, and other ways of knowing*
- *Embrace discomfort, non-closure, and disagreement*
- *Be accountable for the impact of our words and actions*
- *Give and receive feedback in a way that encourages listening, learning, and personal growth*

Academic Integrity

In this course, plagiarism is defined as the use or reproduction of the work of another author (individual, or organization) without proper acknowledgement or citation. If any type of academic misconduct is suspected, the appropriate investigation and possible sanctions will be carried out in consultation with student services

In this course, students are discouraged from using advanced automated tools (artificial intelligence or machine learning tools such as ChatGPT or Dall-E 2). If you choose to consult with these tools, you are responsible for ensuring their accuracy and clearly citing the way that the AI tool was used. Failure to clearly cite any use of generative AI is considered plagiarism. Please consult with me if you have questions about this policy.

Accommodations

If you have already established accommodations with Disability Resources for Students (DRS), please communicate your approved circumstances to me at your earliest convenience so we can discuss your needs in this course. If you have not yet established services through DRS, but have a temporary health condition or permanent disability that requires accommodations (conditions include but not limited to; mental health, attention-related, learning, vision, hearing, physical or health impacts), you are welcome to contact DRS at 206- 543-8924 or uwdrs@uw.edu or disability.uw.edu. DRS offers resources and coordinates reasonable accommodations for students with disabilities and/or temporary health conditions.

Washington state law requires that UW develop a policy for accommodation of student absences or significant hardship due to reasons of faith or conscience, or for organized religious activities. The UW's policy, including more information about how to request an accommodation, is available at Faculty Syllabus Guidelines and Resources. Information on this policy can be found below. Please notify me immediately if you expect a need for accommodation.

<https://registrar.washington.edu/students/religious-accommodations-request/>